times, rush to smother the straighter ones. We just about survive each ball for the next ten minutes.

In a bizarre flood of unusual calm, time stretching into a blur now, we are somehow getting closer. The sensation surrounding us changes from foregone conclusion to vague possibility. As we inch closer, the reality hits me that maybe for the first time in my life *I* am the senior batter in this situation. It is my job to read the situation, protect the strike, shepherd a country home. A feeling of make-believe becoming reality fills me; a ghost of a childhood memory of dreaming about being in this situation as I played against the garage back home. It's all down to *me*. I begin to give Monty more specific, precise instructions. 'Make sure you watch the ball,' I'm telling him again and again before Siddle bowls. 'If it's short, make sure your hands are down, and just let it hit you. If it's full and straight, make sure your bat is there.' Nathan Hauritz is finding those foot holes, causing the ball to spit and turn away from both our bats. 'Protect the stumps,' I tell Monty, with the air of someone whose highest score is more than 49 not out off 50 overs for Burnley Cricket Club, 'and if it's outside and spinning, leave it alone.' It's unclear, to both of us, whether I am telling myself this or Monty, but he nods dutifully, the puzzled smile now gone, a sense of purpose now occupying his body language.

There is a harnessing, supportive energy suddenly emerging, an excitement of watching something unexpected, every single ball receiving a deathly silence before the bowler runs in. Once survived, it is cheered, celebrated, whooped and praised to the heavens before the silence descends again. It's a rush to suddenly have every block or leave celebrated. It's like, as I have grown accustomed to Test cricket occasionally gifting me, the outside is aligning with the inside, my usual internal monologue for surviving even one ball now sharing the same rapture outside it too.

While it happens, I begin to feel deep admiration and affection for Monty. His path to this moment is as unlikely as mine and in a moment of understanding this too, the Welsh crowd are now singing my song but changing the words to his name. We are quietly coming to understand something as we block and shrug and survive. We sit inside a transformation that sport can occasionally impact on a person, whether they are willing or otherwise. We are learning, through the sheer calamity of the situation, that we are capable of more than we, or anyone else, would have